

Medieval Latin Essay

Contrasting Impacts of Vernacular and Context Upon Latin in Medieval England (c. 11th-15th centuries)

For centuries after the Roman conquest, Latin continued to be used commonly in England until circa the 16th century (Wright, 2017). Throughout the medieval period, Latin diverged from Classical origin, for both vernacular influence and mandates of the contexts of Latin's use; this essay argues that while both reasons are important, the former is overstated, with the latter being far more significant.

To overview 11th-14th century England, Middle English was spoken, French used in court, and Latin used in documentation and Church (Childs, 2017). Such arrangement came about due to the Norman French nobility and an existing Latin culture across Europe, with Latin becoming the documentary language as a natural consequence of its use within the Church: clergy, being most literate, did most early writing (ibid.). Latin continued to be used for documentation because of its exact nature determined by formal rules; English only began to be frequently used in writing from the 14th century after experiencing the beginnings of its own standardisation (Dodd, 2019). Though even with increased use of English, Latin persisted: while by Edward III's 1362 statute, English replaced French as the spoken language of court, court documents continued to use Latin — Latin also being used across the Channel, so tying English law with that practised on the Continent (Ormrod, 2003).

While Latin remained the formal, written language in England until the 16th century, note that often documents were drafted in English or French, and only finalised in Latin (ibid.). Naturally, translation dilemmas emerged with items or practices not common of the Classical world, requiring substitution of either another Latin word — so prescribing to it a new meaning — or latinising a native word, i.e. remodelling it in a Latin matrix (ibid.). The latter offered clarity for readers: substituted Latin conflicts the original and contextual meanings when a closer native or lay word could be used. For example, native *SCIRA* makes appearance in the Domesday Book for “shire”, though Roman *PROVINCIA* and *REGIO* (province/region) were common pre-Conquest and *COMITATUS* or *VICECOMITATUS* (county/vice-county) post (Sharpe, 2017), with no Classical substitute quite capturing the English meaning.

Beyond strict use of Latin waning as Norman influence dwindled, we here observe how the appropriate word can be subject to the author, and particularly how that changed in the Norman mind. COMITATUS reflected land-division familiar to Normans; likewise COMES and VICECOMES were introduced for ealdorman and sheriff, equating these with Norman *conte* and *visconte* for count and vice-count, while pre-Conquest DUX was favoured for ealdorman — which Normans considered too lofty a term (ibid.). There is also record of ALDREMANNUS, from English, in writ translation circa 1100 (ibid.).

However, the substitution of existing Latin words was actually favoured in England – in contrast to the Continent. The reason is contextual: England was unique in having a complex relationship of three written languages; the Normans, for example, spoke only French and wrote only Latin (Howlett, 2017). Latin was learned in England, not spoken natively, and was therefore practised differently. Particularly in the North, where there was a greater influence from the Irish branch of Latin, the exactness of Latin was favoured over an individual’s rhetoric or style (ibid.), with mongrel “English-Latin” unlikeable for straying from pure Roman form.

Nevertheless, the use of the vernacular did rise over time — especially with an increase in international trade, and science and technology, demanding greater need for precision in writing (Childs, 2017). Novel discoveries and inventions could be more clearly referenced in English (Ashdowne, 2018), for example, words relating to mills in the 1278-1538 *Account Rolls of the Abbey of Durham* used MILNE from English *mylen* (e.g. MILNESTANES “mill-stones”, MILNPOSTE “mill-post”) rather than Classical MOLINA (Roig-Marín, 2022). This was most common of compound words, where also “house” may be *hous*, not DOMUS; “nail” *nayl*, not CLAVUS (Wright, 2017).

Moreover, in customs accounts, it was useful to use terms familiar to those handling the goods, rather than Latin approximations that might vary between writers so requiring guesswork to translate. When recording fish from the North Sea unfamiliar to Roman writers, it was not uncommon to use a Nordic name, rather than the name of a wholly different fish from the Mediterranean (Childs, 2017). As the need for rigorous law, too, expanded, it was not English but French that provided new jargon included in documents, hence Legal French (Dodd, 2019).

Vernacular would mostly feature in informal writing: the inquiries of the Domesday survey, for instance, had more English than the final book; formal documents sought to adhere more

closely to Latin (Sharpe, 2017), again demonstrating favour for “correct” Latin. Where a Latin substitute was used often indicated the text being a Latin translation rather than a document originally written in Latin (ibid.).

Though what did arise was intentional use of vernacular in recognition of national identity rather than for comprehension (Roberts & Tinti, 2020), especially from the 15th century onwards (Wright, 2017). Deviation from standard Latin was certainly intentional, as medieval writers were keenly familiar with the Roman classics from which they had learned (Ashdowne, 2018), moreover because English, as a non-Romance language, maintained distinction from Latin, and did not naturally intrude (Howlett, 2017).

But leaving the 14th century, distinction between English and Latin was slowly lost. Accordingly, an effect was had on Latin, and this owed itself to Latin’s role in English culture. First, abbreviations would be common for both English and Latin text, such as “e.g.” and “&” (as an abbreviation of ET) (Wright, 2017). This highlights Latin’s presence in concise and formulaic documentary practice.

Second, English words in Latin text began to drop Latin matrices (ibid.). First, abbreviation symbols were used in place of Latin case endings; then, circa 1390, adherence to Latin cases was phased out, with distinct English endings replacing them: *-ing* for verbs, *-ys* for plurals, and so on (ibid.). Wright depicts a transition during the 14th century of words from Latin to Anglo-Norman to Middle English.

Far earlier than this, in the 11th century Bayeux tapestry, we observe unmistakably Anglo-Saxon spelling – for instance in the use of EADWARDUS over EDWARDUS in scene 27, and the use of Anglo-Saxon letters such as “Ð” (Owen-Crocker, 2002). In fact, such spelling was favoured prior to 1066 (Bernstein, 1986), with Normans imposing stricter adherence to regular Classical Latin. Notably the Carolingian dynasty encouraged proper use of Classical Latin as a means of governing a multi-ethnic people (Roberts & Tinti, 2020). Moreover the English had a more detached relationship with Latin, associating it primarily with the Church who had reintroduced it after the departure of the Roman Empire, whilst on the Continent the ties to Rome persisted (ibid.). Despite the tapestry commemorating Norman victory, it was likely produced in England (Owen-Crocker, 2002). The decision to use Anglo-Saxon spelling acknowledged the survival of English identity in spite of the conquest (Green, 2016).

Importantly, Latin grammar adjusted to its primarily documentary purpose, so being used more strictly and for clear descriptive purposes (Childs, 2017). Hence, when compared to the

poetry of Classical Latin, there was more frequent use of abbreviations for efficiency, and prepositions to describe place and action. Action-focussed Latin emerged, with sentences formatted in the order of Subject, Verb, Object (Owen-Crocker, 2006). This brought Latin syntax closer to English. These effects can be seen in the Bayeux tapestry (Scene 37) (using Leipzig Glossing Rules):

IST-I	PORT-ANT	ARM-AS	AD-NAV-ES	ET-HIC
Those	carry-3PL	arm-ACC.PL	to ship-ACC.PL	and here
TRAH-UNT	CARR-UM	CUM-VIN-O	ET-ARM-IS ¹	
drag-3PL	cart-ACC.SG	with wine-ABL.SG	and arm-ABL.PL	

would be written as

IST-I	ARM-AS	NAV-ES	PORT-ANT	ET	HIC
Those	arm-ACC.PL	ship-ACC.PL	carry-3PL	and	here
CARR-UM	VIN-O	ARM-IS-QUE	TRAH-UNT		
cart-ACC.SG	wine-ABL.SG	arm-ABL.PL	and	drag-3PL	

in Classical Latin, with the verb at the end; perhaps the omission of the preposition AD; perhaps too the omission of CUM, which is implied by the ablative case; and the suffix -QUE in place of ET for flow — a practice less popular in England in favour of simplicity. A Classical poet might also have used ATQUE in the middle to emphasise the labour — which the medieval writer would more likely view as inordinate. Again, these changes were not for ignorance of Latin standards, as English writers of Latin were all educated on Classical technique, but chose to develop their own style (Ashdowne, 2018).

It is also pertinent to consider beyond the medieval period, into the Renaissance and Reformation, when Latin ebbed back into more Classical form (Ashdowne, 2018). The connotation here speaks of Latin's very specific role in English society, which ceded the continued merging of Latin and English vernacular — or any efforts to make Latin more modern or practical — unreasonable in favour of just using English, especially as English became more popular for forms of documentation (Childs, 2017). In the limited contexts within which Latin survived, it did because of tradition, not because it offered any practical benefits over English as it had once done in the medieval period. For one, in the Catholic

¹ “Those men carry arms to the ships, and here they drag a cart with wine and arms”.

Church, where of course there is direct connexion to Rome. Had, alternatively, the vernacular had more influence upon Latin in medieval England, then English written language today, if not Latin, would have a stronger resemblance to it.

As evident from this discussion, the influence of its contexts of use had the greater impact upon the development of Latin in England through the medieval period. While at first it would seem the vernacular influence upon Latin would be strong, the fact is that the injection of vernacular was rare and strictly intentional, rather than progressively becoming the norm. In the situations where it was used, it was done so by necessity of the context — for example, international trade — and moreover, often limited to informal documentation, not becoming a standard of the language.

Word Count: 1,626

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